

« England was not ready to maximise the 2017 World Cup win »

BETH BARRETT-WILD

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In 2013, after a string of media and administrative roles in domestic cricket, Beth Barrett-Wild began her career at the England and Wales Cricket Board (ECB) as a media manager.

In the decade since, she has had a ringside view of the evolution of the women's game, key milestones such as the 2017 Women's ODI World Cup, the ECB's policy changes to professionalise women's cricket, its directives on equal pay, and the revamp of the domestic structure, to name a few.

One of the minds behind The Hundred, the ECB's flagship 100-ball domestic league, she was later elevated to Director of the Women's Professional Game and eventually tournament director for the upcoming Women's T20 World Cup.

As she looks to maximise the platform of a home World Cup to push the ecosystem a notch higher in participation and economic viability, Barrett-Wild, in an exclusive interview with *Sportstar*, underlines the value of The Hundred, why the mistakes made after the 2017 World Cup triumph should not be repeated, and much more. Excerpts:

You spearheaded what became a transformational endeavour for

the women's game in England. What were some of the broader visions you began with that have endured into The Hundred?

I was fortunate to be involved with The Hundred pretty much from its inception in 2018 until it launched in 2021. From the outset, the premise was about throwing cricket's doors open to more people, especially families and young people, and making the sport as accessible as possible. Moreover, the co-presentation of the men's and women's games from the start made the property unique and was baked into the competition's DNA, as opposed to the women's competition being rolled on subsequently, which is what we have historically seen. It helped us create this enormous platform and scale for women's cricket and has been hugely transformative.

You joined the England and Wales Cricket Board in 2014. Looking back, was this scale of growth anticipated?

The game is almost unrecognisable. The first wave of professional contracts came here in 2014. We then had the Kia Super League — the original franchise-style tournament in England and Wales — which was

probably a bit before its time and, this might sound crass, before anyone really cared. Then the high of the 2017 World Cup came along, which was a lightbulb moment for the game here. We realised a different kind of audience was coming through. For the 2026 edition, we know that around 36 per cent of our ticket buyers are female, compared to an England men's fixture where that proportion stands at 18 per cent. A different demographic, and a slightly younger one, has gravitated towards the sport.

The 2017 World Cup pushed us to write our Transform Women and Girls Cricket Action Plan. Off the back of that, full professionalism of the domestic structure came along in 2020 and The Hundred followed in 2021. The professional contracts in 2014 weren't worth an awful lot. But today, someone like Nat Sciver-Brunt, across all her earning opportunities, endorsements and such, could in all likelihood make a million pounds.

Casual fans who discover the game need to be converted into long-term enthusiasts. How do you ensure an exercise like this isn't a flash in the pan?

One of our big objectives is to make